Name: _____

DBQ: Source Analysis Sheets

EQ: Is the censorship of books and information dangerous to society? Why or why not?

Title of Document: Fahrenheit 451 (Part One: The woman who burns with her books)	**Source:** Fahrenheit 451 (novel), Ballantine Books
Date of Publication: 1953	**Author:** Ray Bradbury
After you read over the document, fill in the boxes below.	
1. EVIDENCE: Quote important evidence from this document. You MUST include citations. *Setting: firemen soak an old woman's books in kerosene and order her to leave her house.* "[Type her exact words when she kneels among the soaked books and refuses to give them up.]" (Bradbury ___)	**2. INFERENCE: What does the evidence mean/show?** The woman values her books more than her own safety. She will not let the firemen separate her from them, even when Beatty is counting down and she knows what will happen. This shows that books hold something people cannot live without, such as ideas, memories, and a sense of who they are. Her calm refusal also turns her from a victim into a protester, and the firemen are the ones who run away.
3. ANALYSIS: What does the evidence reveal about censorship on the whole? Censorship is not just destroying paper, it is attacking what makes a person human. Montag has always believed that burning books only hurts things, so no one's conscience is bothered. This woman proves that belief is false, because she would rather die than lose her books. Censorship works by convincing people that no one is being harmed, but the people who love ideas are harmed most. When someone is willing to die to keep an idea alive, it shows how valuable free access to information is.	**4. CONCLUSION: How does this source help support your answer to the essential question?** This source supports my answer that censorship of books and information is dangerous to society. When a society burns its books, it takes away the thing that gives people meaning, and in this scene it even costs a woman her life. It also shows that censors depend on people not noticing the harm. Once Montag sees a real person suffer for her books, he can no longer pretend that censorship is harmless, which is how the danger first becomes visible.

Source Analysis Sheet

Title of Document: Fahrenheit 451 (Part Two: Mildred and the parlor "family")	**Source:** Fahrenheit 451 (novel), Ballantine Books
Date of Publication: 1953	**Author:** Ray Bradbury
After you read over the document, fill in the boxes below.	
1. EVIDENCE: Quote important evidence from this document. You MUST include citations. *Setting: Montag reads aloud from the books he hid, and Mildred refuses to listen.* "[Type Mildred's exact words saying books are not people and that her 'family' is people.]" (Bradbury ___)	**2. INFERENCE: What does the evidence mean/show?** Mildred cares more about the actors on her parlor walls than about the real people in her life. She calls them her "family" and thinks books are fake because no one in them talks back to her. This shows that she can no longer tell entertainment from real connection. The screens give her constant noise and attention, so she feels busy and happy, but she is actually isolated and has no one who really knows her.
3. ANALYSIS: What does the evidence reveal about censorship on the whole? Censorship does not always need a ban or a fire. Here, society has replaced books with endless distraction, and people give up reading on their own. Mildred even defends the thing that is numbing her. When a culture fills every quiet moment with shallow entertainment, no one has time or desire to think, ask questions, or notice what is missing. That kind of censorship is dangerous because it feels like freedom and fun, so people never realize they have lost something.	**4. CONCLUSION: How does this source help support your answer to the essential question?** This source supports my answer that censorship is dangerous to society because it can quietly take away real thought and real human connection. Mildred is not forced to stop reading. She simply stops caring, and that makes her lonely and easy to control. If a society loses books and replaces them with constant noise, people become empty and cannot recognize their own unhappiness, which is a serious danger even without any laws forbidding ideas.

Source Analysis Sheet

Title of Document: Fahrenheit 451 (Part One: Clarisse McClellan)	**Source:** Fahrenheit 451 (novel), Ballantine Books
Date of Publication: 1953	**Author:** Ray Bradbury
After you read over the document, fill in the boxes below.	
1. EVIDENCE: Quote important evidence from this document. You MUST include citations. *Setting: Clarisse tells Montag what she has noticed from listening to people in the subway and cafes.* "[Type Clarisse's exact words about what people talk about.]" (Bradbury ___)	**2. INFERENCE: What does the evidence mean/show?** Clarisse sees that conversation has become empty. People only name cars, clothes, and pools, and everyone says the same things, so no one says anything different from anyone else. This shows a society where people no longer share real ideas or opinions with each other. Clarisse stands out because she still asks "why" and pays attention, which makes her seem strange to everyone around her.
3. ANALYSIS: What does the evidence reveal about censorship on the whole? Censorship kills curiosity and independent thought. When books and different viewpoints disappear, people have nothing new to talk about and nothing to question, so everyone ends up thinking alike. Clarisse is called "anti-social" for asking questions, and later Beatty says she was dangerous for wanting to know why instead of how. Society punishes the people who think for themselves, which shows that censorship is about control: a population that does not ask questions is easy to manage.	**4. CONCLUSION: How does this source help support your answer to the essential question?** This source supports my answer that censorship is dangerous to society because it destroys the curiosity and honest conversation a society needs to improve itself. Without different ideas, no one can notice problems, such as the violence and loneliness Clarisse describes, and no one can fix them. A society that treats questions as a threat cannot grow, and that makes censorship harmful for everyone, not just for readers.

Source Analysis Sheet

Title of Document: Fahrenheit 451 (Part One: Captain Beatty explains how book burning began)	**Source:** Fahrenheit 451 (novel), Ballantine Books
Date of Publication: 1953	**Author:** Ray Bradbury
After you read over the document, fill in the boxes below.	
1. EVIDENCE: Quote important evidence from this document. You MUST include citations. *Setting: Beatty visits Montag at home and gives a long speech about the history of the firemen.* "[Type Beatty's exact words saying it did not come from the Government and that technology, mass exploitation, and minority pressure did the job.]" (Bradbury ___)	**2. INFERENCE: What does the evidence mean/show?** Beatty says that book burning did not begin with a government order. It grew out of the public itself, as media got shorter and simpler and as every group demanded that nothing offend them. This shows that people helped create censorship because they wanted comfort and wanted to avoid being upset. Beatty presents this as a good thing, which shows how easily a society can talk itself into believing that removing ideas keeps everyone happy.
3. ANALYSIS: What does the evidence reveal about censorship on the whole? Censorship can come from the people, not only from rulers. Each small step seems harmless: shortening books, removing anything controversial, avoiding offense. But together they leave a world with nothing challenging left to read. By the time firemen become official censors, most people have already agreed to it. This makes censorship especially dangerous, because there is no single villain to resist and the loss feels like a choice people made for themselves.	**4. CONCLUSION: How does this source help support your answer to the essential question?** This source supports my answer that censorship is dangerous to society because it can grow quietly from ordinary people's wish to avoid discomfort. A society that removes every idea that might upset someone ends up with no ideas worth having. Beatty's speech is a warning that protecting freedom of information takes constant effort from everyone, since once people stop defending books, the damage is very hard to reverse.

Source Analysis Sheet

Title of Document: Fahrenheit 451 (Part Two: Faber explains what society is missing)	**Source:** Fahrenheit 451 (novel), Ballantine Books
Date of Publication: 1953	**Author:** Ray Bradbury
After you read over the document, fill in the boxes below.	
1. EVIDENCE: Quote important evidence from this document. You MUST include citations. *Setting: Montag visits the retired professor Faber and asks why books matter.* "[Type Faber's exact words listing the three things that are missing: quality of information, leisure to digest it, and the right to act on it.]" (Bradbury ___)	**2. INFERENCE: What does the evidence mean/show?** Faber says books are not magic. What matters is what they contain: detailed, truthful information about life, time to think about it, and the freedom to act on what you learn. This shows that a free society needs all three together. Without books, people only get fast, shallow information from screens and never have the time or the freedom to question it.
3. ANALYSIS: What does the evidence reveal about censorship on the whole? Censorship does more than remove books. It removes the quality of what people learn, the time they have to think about it, and the freedom to act on their conclusions. Faber points out that the televisor tells people what to think and rushes them along so fast that their minds do not have time to object. That makes censorship a tool for controlling how people think, not just what they read. A population that cannot think for itself cannot protect its own freedom.	**4. CONCLUSION: How does this source help support your answer to the essential question?** This source supports my answer that censorship is dangerous to society because it takes away the tools people need to think and govern themselves. Faber shows that when information is shallow, time to reflect is gone, and people lose the right to act, society cannot correct its mistakes. Because books can hold these things together, the loss of books leaves people unable to question authority, which makes censorship a threat to the whole community.

In the space below, collect quotes (with page numbers!) from *Fahrenheit 451* that you feel may help you answer the essential question: **Is the censorship of books and information dangerous to society? Why or why not?**

1. HARM "[the old woman's words about her books]" (Bradbury ___)
   Shows that books are worth more to people than their own safety.
2. HARM "[Clarisse on what people talk about]" (Bradbury ___)
   Shows that without different ideas, conversation and thinking become empty.
3. HARM "[Beatty on cramming people with facts so they feel like they're thinking]" (Bradbury ___)
   Shows that censorship can fake knowledge and leave people feeling informed while they stay uninformed.
4. HARM "[Faber on the televisor telling you what to think]" (Bradbury ___)
   Shows that constant screens leave no time to question or protest.
5. WHY SOCIETY ALLOWS IT "[Beatty: it didn't come from the Government]" (Bradbury ___)
   Shows that censorship can start with the public's own choices.
6. WHY SOCIETY ALLOWS IT "[Beatty: a book is a loaded gun in the house next door]" (Bradbury ___)
   Shows how censors justify burning books as protecting people from being upset or made to feel inferior.
7. HOPE "[Granger on keeping the books in their heads]" (Bradbury ___)
   Shows that ideas can survive censorship when people protect them.
8. HOPE "[Granger on what the group tells lonely people they are doing]" (Bradbury ___)
   Shows that remembering and passing on ideas is how a society can recover.